



**ASSESSMENT CENTRE:
GRADUATE DEVELOPMENT PROGRAM (Group)**

Assessment Centre Guide

For BSP Graduate Development Candidate

Dear **Gabrielle**,

Welcome and Congratulation on being selected to undergo the **BSP 2027 Graduate Development Assessment Centre**.

The Assessment Centre is comprised of **three parts**:

PART 1: Individual Challenge Task & 10 Minute Pitch Presentation

Description: You will receive a case study containing background information and context 24 hours before your scheduled interview. The case study will include a problem statement and a challenge statement.

Task: You are required to prepare a 10-minute pitch presentation, supported by a Microsoft PowerPoint slide deck of no more than 10 slides.

PART 2: 8 Competency-Based Interview Questions

Description: You will be asked eight questions aligned to the eight core competencies, with each question framed in the context of the case study.

Task: Review the competencies listed below and familiarise yourself with the case study in preparation for the interview.

The 8 competencies that will be measured are:

1. **Drive:** Proactive and self-motivated, consistently taking initiative in their own learning and in projects. They set high personal standards, work diligently to meet deadlines, and demonstrate the potential to grow into future leadership roles.
2. **Learning Agility:** Quickly grasps new concepts and applies them effectively across different business areas. Adaptable in unfamiliar situations and eager to learn from each rotation, applying knowledge to contribute meaningfully to diverse projects.
3. **Analytical Thinking:** Strong problem-solver with the ability to think creatively, analyse data, and identify effective solutions. Makes sound decisions based on evidence, logic, and critical evaluation of different perspectives.
4. **Adaptability:** Thrives in changing environments, adjusting smoothly to new teams, tasks, and priorities. Handles challenges positively and maintains high performance in dynamic situations.
5. **Language Proficiency:** Communicates ideas clearly and effectively in written and verbal formats, including reports, presentations, and everyday interactions. Able to convey messages in a way that builds understanding and trust.
6. **Original Thinking:** Brings fresh, innovative ideas to improve processes, services, and solutions. Thinks beyond conventional approaches to add value across different projects and business areas.
7. **Teamwork:** Works well with diverse teams, building positive relationships and contributing to shared goals. Balances individual accountability with collaboration for collective success.
8. **Language Complexity:** Uses clear and concise language to ensure understanding, focusing on effectiveness rather than overly complex or technical vocabulary. Able to adapt communication style for different audiences.

PART 3: Technical Questions Aligned to the Business Unit Need

Description: You will be asked questions specific to the Business Unit conducting your interview.

Task: Review the background information on the Business Unit and prepare for potential technical questions that may be asked. As a new graduate with no work experience, the focus will be on how well you think, structure your responses, and apply your academic or theoretical knowledge to practical scenarios. The assessment will also consider how effectively you demonstrate learning agility rather than relying on industry experience.

Background Information on the Business Unit that will interview you:

Division Name	Finance & Strategy
Description of the Business	The Finance & Strategy Division is responsible to the effective management of the Group's financial resources, ensuring that the company's financial records are authentic and in order. Headed by the Group Financial Officer. The SBU consists of several Reporting teams that are required to meet internal and external reporting requirements, providing support to various stakeholders as required. Aside from the reporting teams, the Procurement and Purchasing team continue to support all other SBUs with their purchasing needs and remains an important point of contact when dealing with existing goods and services providers, whilst the Accounts Payable team ensures that BSP's accounts are settled on time and any disputes are resolved amicably. On the other hand, the Strategy team continues to manage the strategic planning process, investor presentations, and reporting cycles and coordinate the delivery of Board-mandated strategic priorities across the Group. • Finance and Planning comprises of the following Business Unit(BU): • Financial Reporting; • Management Reporting; • Investor Relations & Strategy Office; • Insurance; • Regulatory & Risk Reporting; • Accounts Operations; • Data Analytics; • People & Projects; • BSP (PNG) Life; • OSB/SUB Finance Team.

Tips to Perform Your Best

- ✓ Check your tech - Ensure you have Microsoft Teams installed and a stable internet connection.
- ✓ Prepare early – Review the case study as soon as you receive it.
- ✓ Think about the customer first – Every solution should help real people.
- ✓ Use data to back your ideas – Show your reasoning.
- ✓ Be creative but practical – Your ideas should be bold yet doable.
- ✓ Communicate clearly – Explain your thinking step-by-step.

Should you have any questions or concerns, please contact the **BSP Talent Acquisition** Team via email gdppg@bsp.com.pg or phone 305 7735 should you have any questions.

All the Best & Good Luck!

Zani Mashinini
Head of Talent, Learning, Leadership & Culture
BSP Financial Group Limited

1. INDIVIDUAL CHALLENGE TASK: Developing a Data-Driven Strategic Recovery Plan for Meridian Pacific Bank

Bank Name	Meridian Pacific Bank
Motto	"Stronger communities, connected through banking."
Problem Statement	The following three problems have been formally escalated to the Executive Leadership Team. Each carries both short-term and long-term consequences for the bank's financial health, competitive position, and social licence to operate in Torova. You are expected to engage with all three, though your strategy need not attempt to fully solve each one.
Individual Task	You have 24 hours to Analyse, Develop and Prepare a 10-minute Presentation in Microsoft Powerpoint slide (Not More than 10 Sides): ▪ Analyse the situation using the data provided. ▪ Complete two sequential tasks. Each builds on the previous one. Assessors will evaluate your ability to synthesise information, exercise judgment under ambiguity, and translate insight into action. Your Task: 1. Using the data provided, identify the most critical problem facing Meridian Pacific Bank and justify your selection using at least two specific data points drawn from the tables. Then rank Problems A, B, and C in order of urgency, explaining the trade-offs you considered — including the tension between short-term financial performance and the bank's long-term obligation to advance financial inclusion across Torova. 2. Propose a clear 12–18 month strategy for MPB that addresses at least two key issues. Include: • 2–3 initiatives with owners and expected outcomes • Key Pacific constraints to consider Prepare a 10-minute presentation to the board outlining: You have been selected as part of a Graduate Strategy Intake Team, tasked by the CEO's office with developing a credible, evidence-based response to the bank's most pressing strategic challenges. You will present your analysis and recommendations to a panel of assessors simulating MPB's Executive Leadership Team, including the Chief Financial Officer, and Head of Retail Banking. Focus 1: Profitability Under Pressure - MPB's Net Interest Margin has declined from 5.8% in FY2022 to 4.9% in FY2024, driven by a combination of rising funding costs, competitive pressure on lending rates from smaller and more agile rivals, and a loan impairment rate that has grown from 3.1% to 4.8% over the same period. The cost-to-income ratio has climbed to 43.7% — well above the Board's target of under 38% — partly due to the operational cost of maintaining an extensive physical branch network in a geographically dispersed, low-density market. The agricultural and fishing segment, which accounts for 14% of the loan book, is the highest-risk portfolio, with a default rate of 9.2% driven largely by climate-related income disruptions and limited capacity for borrowers to provide collateral or formal repayment schedules. match without significant re-architecture. Focus Area 2: Digital Disruption and Competitive Erosion - Pacific Digital Finance (PDF), a mobile-first fintech startup backed by regional venture capital, has grown its market share from 2% to 9% in just three years. Its NPS of 68 is nearly three times MPB's current score of 24. PDF's

core proposition is simple: no branch visits, no paper documentation, and lending decisions made within 48 hours via an AI-assisted credit scoring model that uses mobile transaction history as a proxy for creditworthiness. This approach resonates particularly strongly with the 18–34 age cohort, which represents 41% of Torova's adult population.

MPB's digital transaction share has grown from 19% to 36% over three years, and active mobile banking users have more than doubled to 341,000 — indicating appetite for digital services. However, the bank's core banking system is over 14 years old, and the average time to onboard a new retail customer remains 4–6 days, compared to PDF's fully digital process completed in under two hours.

Focus Area 3: **Financial Inclusion Imperative** - Over 72% of Torova's adult population remains unbanked or underbanked. Rural and outer island communities face acute barriers: an average of 74 kilometres to the nearest bank branch, low literacy rates in financial products, a high proportion of residents without formal identification documents, and inconsistent mobile network coverage across remote atolls. The Central Bank of Torova's 40% inclusion target by 2030 creates a regulatory expectation that MPB — as the market leader — will play a significant role in closing this gap.

Current agent banking coverage reaches 17 of Torova's 24 island districts, but agent quality and product range vary significantly. Community trust in informal savings mechanisms — known locally as "namlali" groups — remains high, with an estimated 340,000 adults participating in these community-based savings circles that operate entirely outside the formal financial system.

1. Expected Output for 10-minute Pitch presentation:

- Develop a strategic plan to improve one or more of the focus areas.
- Suggest innovations (digital and human) that can bridge access gaps.
- Highlight how your design builds trust, improves access, and supports financial growth.
- Use data where applicable and draw inspiration from customer experiences in other developing markets. You may also prototype interfaces, write scripts for agents, or sketch process flows.

2. Suggested questions you can consider answering in your pitch:

- Explain how you can improve customer trust & engagement while identifying risk & how you would manage it (e.g. satisfaction scores, data analysis, channel usage).
- Briefly outline the potential financial impact of your solution (e.g. customer growth, cost-efficiency, loan uptake).
- Consider existing infrastructure and digital penetration levels when proposing solutions.
- Propose how your design protects vulnerable customers (e.g. low literacy, no documentation) from exclusion or harm.

Pro Tip for Candidates:

The most common mistake in a time-pressured exercise like this is trying to say everything. Identify your strongest two or three points, make them well, and use the Q&A to demonstrate depth on the areas you chose not to cover.

What Assessors Are Looking For

Assessors will not be evaluating candidate on design aesthetic or slide polish. They are assessing candidate thinking. The key questions your presentation must answer are:

- Do you understand what the actual problem is, and can you distinguish symptoms from root causes?
- Are your recommendations grounded in the data provided, or do they ignore evidence in favour of generic solutions?
- Can you explain the commercial logic of your strategy clearly and confidently?
- How do you respond when challenged? Do you defend your reasoning constructively, or do you defer immediately under pressure?
- Is your communication clear, structured, and suited to an executive audience?

BACKGROUND & CONTEXT

Theme: Smarter Banking, Stronger Communities

Overview

Meridian Pacific Bank (MPB) is the largest commercial bank in the fictional Republic of Torova, a Pacific island nation with a population of approximately 8.4 million people spread across a main island and 340 smaller inhabited islands and atolls. MPB was established in 1968 and has grown to become the dominant financial institution in the country, holding a 44% market share across retail, SME, agricultural, and corporate banking segments. The bank employs 4,200 staff and operates 88 branches, more than 2,600 banking agents, and a growing digital banking platform.

Torova's economy is primarily driven by natural resource extraction (mining, forestry, and fishing), subsistence agriculture, and a growing tourism sector. Remittances from Torovans living and working abroad — particularly in Australia, New Zealand, and Fiji — account for approximately 18% of national GDP, making them a critical component of household income for many families across the outer islands.

The Bank's newly appointed Chief Executive, Sione Taufu, has described the challenge plainly: "We are a big bank in a small ocean, and the tide is shifting. We must decide whether we lead the change or are swept aside by it."

The following data has been extracted from MPB's internal performance reports, the Central Bank of Torova's Financial Inclusion Survey (2024), and a commissioned customer research study. You are expected to engage with and reference this data in your presentation. Assessors will specifically probe whether your recommendations are grounded in the evidence provided.

MPB FINANCIAL PERFORMANCE SUMMARY (PGK)

Metric	FY2022	FY2023	FY2024	System Target
Net Profit After Tax (PGK M)	K892M	K974M	K1.02B	K1.15B
Net Interest Margin (NIM)	5.8%	5.4%	4.9%	5.5%
Cost-to-Income Ratio	38.2%	40.1%	43.7%	< 38%

Metric	FY2022	FY2023	FY2024	System Target
Loan Impairment Rate	3.1%	3.6%	4.8%	< 3.0%
Digital Transaction Share	19%	27%	36%	55%
Formally Banked Adults (national)	24%	26%	28%	40% by 2030
Branch Network (total)	94	91	88	Maintain ≥ 85
Active Mobile Banking Users	148K	219K	341K	600K
Customer Satisfaction Score (NPS)	31	28	24	> 50

Note: PGK = Pacific Kina (fictitious currency). 'System Target' refers to targets set by the Board and Central Bank of Torova. NPS = Net Promoter Score (–100 to +100 scale).

CUSTOMER SEGMENT PERFORMANCE (FY2024)

Customer Segment	% of Loan Book	Default Rate	NPS	Primary Pain Point
Urban Salaried (govt & private)	38%	2.1%	38	Slow loan approval (avg. 9 days)
Rural & Subsistence Households	11%	7.4%	19	Distance to branch / agent
SME & Informal Traders	27%	6.8%	22	Collateral requirements, no credit history
Agriculture & Fishing Sector	14%	9.2%	17	Seasonal income, poor documentation
Corporate & Government	10%	0.8%	61	Limited advisory & FX services

Note: Loan book percentages reflect composition of total gross loans as at December 2024. Default rate = loans overdue > 90 days as a proportion of segment lending. NPS scores are segment-specific.

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE OVERVIEW (FY2024)

Institution	Mkt Share	NPS	Key Strength	Key Weakness
Meridian Pacific Bank (incumbent)	44%	24	Widest branch & agent network	Ageing core banking system, slow CX
Coral Coast Commercial Bank	21%	47	Fast digital onboarding, SME focus	Thin rural presence
Island Trust Bank (govt-linked)	18%	39	Public payroll & rural credit schemes	Bureaucratic, high documentation
Pacific Digital Finance (fintech)	9%	68	Mobile-first, 48hr loan decisions	No physical presence, trust deficit
Other (credit unions, MFIs)	8%	N/A	Community trust, flexible terms	Unregulated, limited scale

Note: Market share estimates based on Central Bank of Torova regulatory filings and third-party industry research. NPS for informal sector providers is not measured (N/A).